

PAINT WITH THREAD

A guide to contemporary needlepainting



HOW TO EMBROIDER — THE DARWIN'S TANAGER

— Introduction

Hi there! Thank you so much for picking up this guide to contemporary needlepainting. Whether you are a newbie or an experienced stitcher, I hope you enjoy embroidering this design and learn something new along the way.

This pattern requires only 13 colours, but please feel free to experiment and use as many or as few as you like! The pattern comes with clear colour guides and instructions, but you are always encouraged to add your own personal touch. If you feel more comfortable using another technique, or want to use more than one strand of floss at a time, please do so! You don't even have to keep it in the hoop — you can embroider this design on your jeans, jackets, shirts, handbags, cushions, hats or whatever else takes your fancy.

The embroidery technique used throughout is referred to as needlepainting, though you may know it as long and short stitch, thread painting or silk shading. It is essentially a very free and non-restrictive way to embroider once you get the hang of it.

In an age where everything is instantaneous, it's important to take the time to create something with your own two hands. Embroidery encourages you to sit down, breathe, and ease into an evening (or a whole day!) of creativity and relaxation. I hope you fall in love with this ancient art and show the world how great something can be if you simply take the time to create it.

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— What you will need

- A 6" embroidery hoop
- Medium-weight fabric (cotton calico works great)
- 13 colours of DMC six-strand floss →
- Embroidery needle(s), size 5–10
- A sharp 2B–6B pencil
- Fabric scissors & floss scissors
- White tack and a printer (for the trace pattern)



3799 Pewter Gray Vy Dk



524 Fern Green Vy Lt



838 Beige Brown Vy Dk



3013 Khaki Green Lt



729 Old Gold Medium



926 Gray Green Med



535 Ash Gray Vy Lt



3371 Black Brown



738 Tan Very Light



798 Delft Blue Dark



741 Tangerine Med



3045 Yellow Beige Dk



830 Golden Olive Dk

— Tools explained

FABRIC

Suggested: medium-weight cotton calico

Choose a medium-weight fabric with a close weave — not transparent, but not so heavy that it is hard to pull your needle through. Avoid fabric with any stretch in it. If this is your first time, a light fabric makes it much easier to trace the pattern. Cotton and linen are affordable and look great; old pillowcases can be a great way to start.

HOOP

Suggested: 6" wooden hoop

The most important factor is that the hoop holds your fabric drum-tight. Wooden hoops grip the fabric well and the screw is sturdy and strong. If the fabric loosens whilst embroidering it can cause unsightly puckering; if you struggle to keep it tight, consider wrapping fabric tape around the inner hoop.

THREAD

Suggested: DMC stranded cotton

DMC stranded cotton comes in around 500 colours and the sheen gives your finished embroidery a superior quality. There are six divisible strands, which lets you vary the weight of your stitches. Use one strand at a time for the finest blending; no more than two if you want extra speed. The 13 colours for this pattern are listed on p.4.

NEEDLE

Suggested: size 5/10 embroidery needles

If you are a beginner, use a needle with the smallest eye you feel comfortable threading. Look for needles with an elongated eye and a sharp point. As you get quicker at threading, go down in size — the thinner the needle, the easier it is to embroider through dense stitching.

LIGHT

Suggested: daylight lamp or magnifier

An embroidery light isn't essential, but a white source of light takes the strain off your eyes and helps you see colours accurately. On a budget, a cool white/daylight bulb in an overhead lamp works just fine for stitching at night.

PENCIL

Suggested: extremely sharp 2B–6B pencil

For transferring the pattern, a pencil is great because you can get a really sharp point, which helps with tracing the finer details. If you make a tiny mistake, dab some white tack onto the fabric to fade the line. A softer pencil shows up on fabric without having to press too hard.

— How to trace and transfer

01

Print the separate pattern PDF (the file with 'PRINT' in the name) at **100% scale** — do not use “fit to page”. The dashed circle should measure 152mm across, matching your 6" hoop.

02

Cut along the dashed line so you are left with a circular piece of paper with the design in the centre.

03

Cut a square of pre-ironed fabric roughly 2–3 inches larger than the hoop on all sides. Place the inner hoop down, lay the fabric over it, then press the outer hoop with the screw on top. Keep pulling the fabric on opposing sides while slowly tightening the screw until the fabric is extremely drum-tight.

04

Place four tiny pieces of white tack on the corner marks on the front of the paper circle. Flip the hoop over and lightly press the paper, front side down, onto the back of the fabric. Hold it up to the light and adjust until the design sits in the centre.

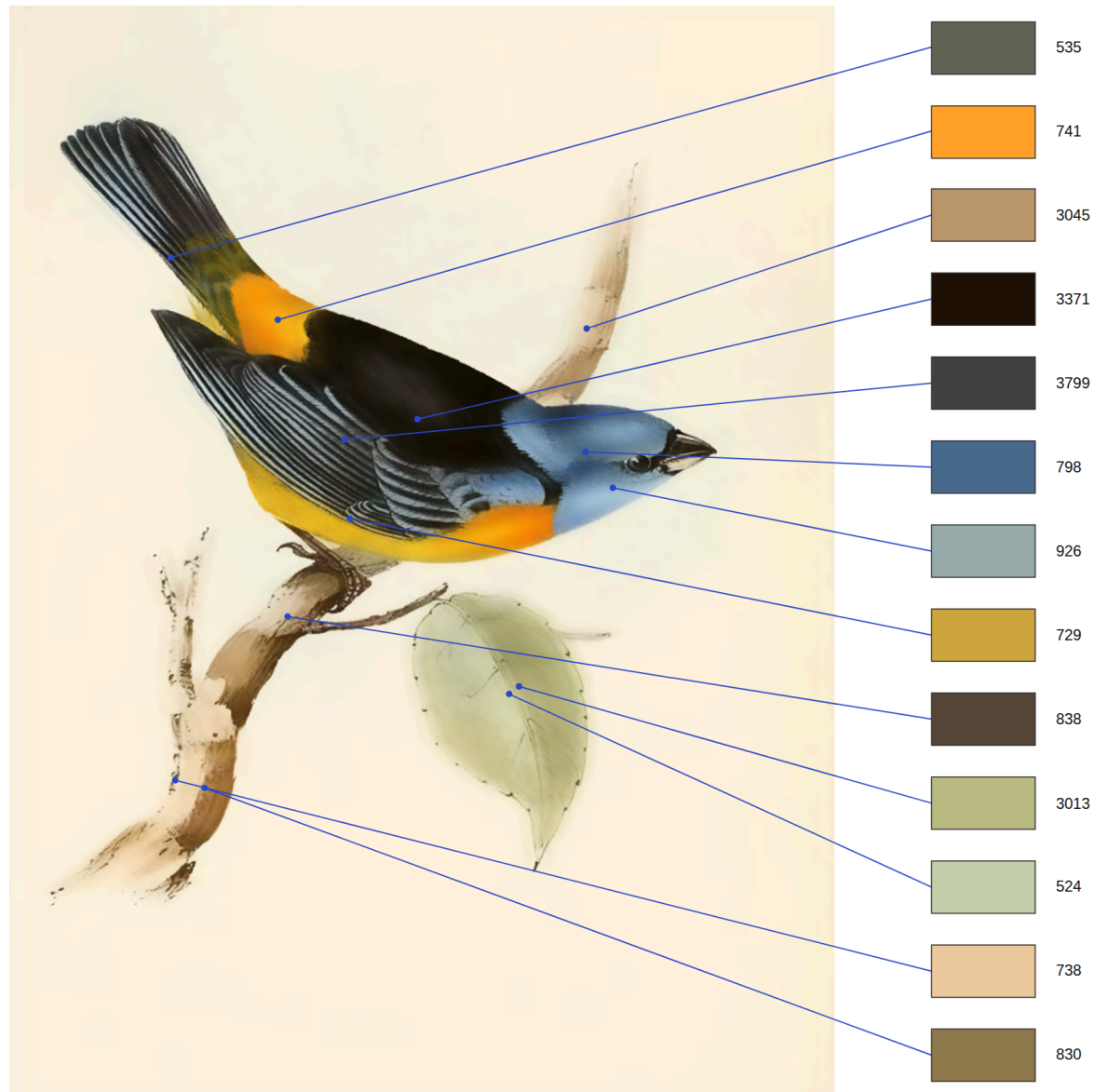
05

With the paper attached to the back, hold the hoop up to a lamp or window. Trace the outline you can see through the fabric with a sharp pencil. Don't move the paper once you begin. Remove the paper — you are ready to embroider!

***Tip:** the tracing process is more vital than you may think. If you rush this step, your finished embroidery will not be as high quality. Sharpen your pencil as soon as it starts to go blunt.*

THE DARWIN'S TANAGER

— Thread colour guide



— Stitch guide

Long and short stitch is an embroidery technique that is fantastic for filling large surface areas of fabric. It is essentially like painting on a canvas, but rather than using paint, you are using thread. The shading is acquired by using a different coloured thread for subsequent rows.

You are embroidering one short stitch, then one long stitch, in a series of rows — but don't worry about making each alternate stitch equal to the last. The more you stagger your stitches at different lengths, the better it looks: you want the longer stitches to be fighting to get into each other's rows. Ensure the stitches are tightly packed together and try not to overlap them — you don't want to see any spaces.

Shading doesn't always follow straight lines. Where there is a curve, angle your rows to follow it, the same way water flows around a river bend. This is especially important with animals and plants: embroider with their natural curves and the motion of their fur or petals. If you get too caught up keeping everything neat and straight without changing direction, it will look unnatural.

***Tip:** when working the second or subsequent rows, bring your needle UP through the previous row and down into the unstitched fabric. Coming up from the unstitched fabric and down into the thread creates unsightly holes.*

— Stitch guide p.2

LONG AND SHORT STITCH

Begin at the simplest place to start your first row. Thread your needle with a knot on the end and come up from the back to make your first stitch. Make another adjacent stitch with a different length. Continue until you have a row with no gaps, then work the next row in the same colour or a new one, always staggering the lengths.

SPLIT STITCH

Split stitch follows a line and is great for outlines. Come up from the back and make one small stitch. Then come up in front of that stitch and go back down through the middle of it, splitting the thread. Keep the stitches as tiny as you can, especially on curves — that's the trick to making it look good.

FRENCH KNOT

After anchoring your thread, pull it to the front and hold it tautly upwards with your free hand. Place the needle against the front of the thread and wind the thread around it twice. Still holding the thread taut, push the needle into the fabric as close as possible to where it came up, and pull through. Voila — a knot! Two strands of floss make a plumper knot.

— Starting to stitch

DIVIDE THE STRANDS

Before you begin stitching, separate the six strands of thread:

1. Cut the length of thread you're going to use from the skein — about the length of your forearm.
2. Gently separate one strand of thread from the six, and you are ready to thread the needle. Use one strand at a time for the finest blending (two at most, or the embroidery can become 'lumpy').

THREAD THE NEEDLE

1. Dampen the tip of the strand on a wet kitchen towel (or use your saliva!).
2. Hold the thread between thumb and index finger and pinch until you can barely see it.
3. Your fingers now support the thread rather than it being floppy — ease it through the eye of the needle. Don't knot the end near the needle; leave a couple of inches loose.

Tip: if the thread is frayed at the end, give it a little trim to help it go through easier.

OPTION ONE — MAKE A KNOT

The simplest way to start and end your stitches, though knots can unravel over a very long time.

1. After threading your needle, create a tiny knot at the far end of the thread.
2. Embroider your stitches.
3. When you have nearly used up the thread, take it to the back of the hoop and knot it as close to the fabric as possible.

OPTION TWO — ANCHOR THE THREAD

Worth learning if the piece will be washed or worn:

1. Choose a starting point *inside* an area you will cover with stitching.
2. Make the tiniest stitch you can, without a knot, leaving a tiny tail on the back.
3. Come back up near the first stitch and go down through the centre of it, splitting it — it should look like a tiny capital "T".
4. Trim the tail and embroider away. Finish the same way.

— Step-by-step

Expected embroidery time until completion: **10-14 hours** · keep the colour guide on p.7 as a constant reference throughout.



01

Thread your needle with one strand of **738** and outline the branch and the bare twig fork with split stitch. Then fill the pale, sunlit faces of the wood with long and short stitch, keeping your rows running lengthways along each branch, the way the grain flows.



02

Using **3045**, work the mid-tone of the branch and twig, blending up into the **738** you have already laid. This is the rounded middle of the wood, turning from light into shadow.



03

With **830**, deepen the shaded underside of the lower branch. Then, still using **830**, scatter a few tiny french knots (two strands, wound twice) for the little speckles and lichen spots along the bark - a lovely touch of realism.



04

Use **838**, the darkest brown, for the deepest branch shadows and the shadowed knot where the branches fork. Outline with split stitch and fill the small dark pockets, then add a couple of french knots for the darkest bark flecks.

DMC colour key

3799

3371

524

738

838

798

3013

741

729

3045

926

830

535

— Step-by-step p.2



05

Now the leaf. Outline it with split stitch in **524**, then fill the lit half with long and short stitch. Angle your rows outward from the central vein towards the edge, following the natural growth of the leaf.



06

Fill the shaded half of the leaf with **3013**, blending into the **524** along the central vein. A line of split stitch in **3013** down the centre marks the vein and finishes the leaf. The foliage is done - now for the tanager itself!



07

Outline the tail and the folded wing with split stitch in **3799**, then fill them with long and short stitch. Follow the sweep of each feather - rows running the length of the tail, and fanning down the wing from shoulder to tip. Let the longer stitches fight into each other's rows so the flight feathers read as layered, not flat.



08

Outline the black mantle across the back with split stitch in **3371**, then fill it with long and short stitch flowing from the neck down towards the tail. Place your needle just outside the outline as you fill, to keep that glossy black edge crisp against the wing.

DMC colour key

3799

3371

524

738

838

798

3013

741

729

3045

926

830

535

— Step-by-step p.3



09

Switch to the vivid **741** for the two orange patches - the bright flash at the base of the back and the flank patch low on the breast. Fill with long and short stitch, curving the rows to sit snugly against the black. This orange is the jewel of the whole piece, so enjoy it!



10

Fill the golden-yellow belly with **729**, blending up into the orange above. Work your rows following the round of the breast, from the throat down towards the feet.



11

Use the soft grey-green **926** for the pale lower flight feathers and the muted coverts where the wing meets the breast. These cool, quiet tones sit between the black wing and the bright belly and give the bird its depth.



12

Outline the head with split stitch in **798**, then fill it with long and short stitch radiating out from around the eye - short rows over the crown, longer ones sweeping down to the throat. Follow the curve of the head so the blue looks rounded and soft, like real feathers.

DMC colour key

3799

3371

524

738

838

798

3013

741

729

3045

926

830

535

— Step-by-step p.4



13

Finally, the face. Fill the stout beak with a few tidy satin stitches in **535**, angled from base to tip, and use the same thread for the dark lore line just in front of the eye. Leave the tiny eye itself: a single french knot of **3371** (two strands) set into the blue gives your tanager its bright, watchful gaze. Your Darwin's Tanager is complete - step back and admire it!

DMC colour key

3799

3371

524

738

838

798

3013

741

729

3045

926

830

535

— How to finish your hoop

TRIM THE HOOP

Cut the excess fabric around the hoop, leaving roughly a one-inch border.
Pinking shears reduce the chances of the fabric fraying.

THE DRAWSTRING METHOD

1. Thread three strands of embroidery floss and tie a large knot at the end.
2. Cut enough floss to go around the whole circle.
3. Sew a simple running stitch around the whole border, then pull the thread tight (needle still attached) — it should all satisfyingly come together at the back.
4. Tie a sturdy knot so it doesn't come apart, and you're done!

Congratulations on finishing **The Darwin's Tanager** — give yourself a big pat on the back for your patience and determination. I hope you enjoyed painting with thread!